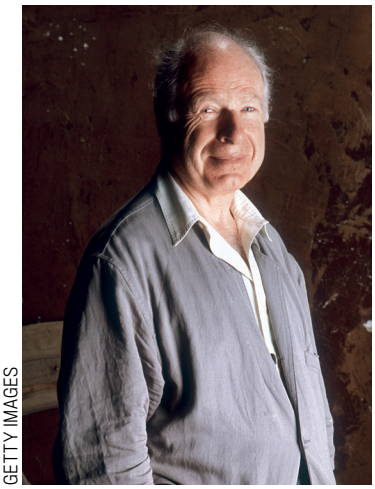
The Illusionist of Journeys

Brook gives us a magnificent theatre of contradictions: a renegade who was what he rebelled against

By Trina Nileena Banerjee

In 1977, journalist and theatre critic John Heilpern wrote his magnum opus *Conference of Birds: The Story of Peter Brook in Africa*, recounting the director's 1972 journey through six countries, across 8,500 miles. Accompanying him were Helen Mirren, Yoshi Oida and other members of his team from the International Centre for Theatre Research, Paris—which Brook had founded in 1970, with a generous grant of close to one million dollars from international funders. Even in his years at the Royal Shakespeare Company in England, Brook had dreamt of a *total subsidy* for the theatre, which would break the constraints of commercial British theatre of the time and allow space for radical experimentation, including the possibility of complete financial failure. Impossible dreams of this nature, which he somehow managed to actualise, frequently defined Brook's magnificent career.

Heilpern describes the Africa journey, which was also a journey towards conceiving Farid ud-Din Attar's 12th-c Persian Sufi poem in performance, as an "expedition... without precedent in the history of theatre". James Roose-Evans writes that it cost nearly $60,000. In an odd way, this journey, and the way it is admiringly recorded by theatre historians, encapsulates much that is both fascinating and difficult about the life of one of the master directors of the twentieth century. Writing from India in 2022, at a moment when creative and intellectual spheres across the world are once again shaken by the urgent call to decolonise, it is impossible to view Brook's universalist, 'intercultural' ambitions without reservation.



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Between the orientalist and the experimentalist, Brook offers no comfortable place to rest to doubter or seeker

Rustom Bharucha's scathing 1988 critique of his *Mahabharata*—which he saw as an offensive instance of "cultural appropriation"—burns with a seething anger that cannot be dismissed offhand. Yet, it is also true that the play was not allowed to tour in India for absurd reasons, both parochial and bigoted, while the film received limited screening. Mallika Sarabhai, who is candid about her difficult relationship as an actress with Brook, recalls how there were racist protests over the fact that Hindu gods were being played by African actors. Also, since B. R. Chopra's *Mahabharata* was running on DD then, it was deemed that the play would confuse audiences! But Sarabhai also affirms that Brook's perspective on the epic was very much that of the Anglo-Saxon male, who shrunk from the intensity of its violence and found it impossible to understand the nature of female power embodied in the character of Draupadi.

There are contradictions at every turn in a journey that seeks to explore Brook. Here was a man who broke through the parochialism of the British theatre in his time, feeling exasperated with its inward-looking, traditional ways. Heilpern quotes him as saying: "...I don't see much hope in any of this. I don't believe it begins to grapple with the essential problem. How to make the theatre absolutely and fundamentally *necessary* to people, as necessary as eating and sex?" The diluted, insipid role theatre played at the time—merely an appendage or cultural decoration to contemporary social life—troubled him. Brook seemed to be looking for some essential core of human life, the secret to which, he believed, the theatre held. Those were the years when Brook began experimentations with his own craft, through spectacular and unprecedented Shakespeare productions. In 1970, just before his move to Paris, came his uniquely visualised *A Midsummer Night's Dream*, which stunned audiences and angered traditional critics. With designer Sally Jacobs, he created Shakespeare's fairy world in a stark white cube with the actors on trapeze bars performing circus tricks.

Biographers paint for us a restless yet patient man, both impatient and resilient: someone dissatisfied not just with the world of theatre-makers and spectators around him, but also with himself and his work, and on a dogged 'spiritual' quest of sorts, for which theatre was simply a means. It seems that, for him, what was true in the theatre was true far beyond it...true everywhere. It is this 'universalist' dimension to his thought that commentators found vague and dissatisfying. Yet, it was this same man who wanted the immediacy of another kind of theatre. In 1966, he staged a damning, brutally satirical experimental protest play, *US*, on American militarism in Vietnam and contemporary British attitudes towards it, documented in the 1967 documentary *Benefit of the Doubt*. From that to his arguably romantic, almost certainly orientalist, search for sonic purity and universal resonance amongst the songs of African tribes, it is difficult to find a comfortable place to rest in Brook's majestic, contradictory, and vast oeuvre. But perhaps that was his life-long idea: the director in Brook's ever-shifting 'empty space' was at once an impostor and a visionary, and like Puck in the ceiling-less expanse of his white-cube forest, impossible to pin down. ■

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